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I

## *The Vegetarian*

Before my wife turned vegetarian, I'd always thought of her as completely unremarkable in every way. To be frank, the first time I met her I wasn't even attracted to her. Middling height; bobbed hair neither long nor short; jaundiced, sickly-looking skin; somewhat prominent cheekbones; her timid, sallow aspect told me all I needed to know. As she came up to the table where I was waiting, I couldn't help but notice her shoes – the plainest black shoes imaginable. And that walk of hers – neither fast nor slow, striding nor mincing.

However, if there wasn't any special attraction, nor did any particular drawbacks present themselves, and therefore there was no reason for the two of us not to get married. The passive personality of this woman in whom I could detect neither freshness nor charm, or anything especially refined, suited me down to the ground. There was no need to affect intellectual leanings in order to win her over, or to worry that she might be comparing me to the preening men who pose in fashion catalogues, and she didn't get worked up if I happened to be late for one of our meetings. The paunch that started appearing in my mid-twenties, my skinny legs and forearms that steadfastly refused to bulk up in spite of my best efforts, the inferiority complex I used to have about the size of my penis – I could rest assured that I wouldn't have to fret about such things on her account.

I've always inclined towards the middle course in life. At school I chose to boss around those who were two or three years my junior, and with whom I could act the ringleader, rather than take my chances with those my own age, and later I chose which college to apply to based on my chances of obtaining a scholarship large enough for my needs. Ultimately, I settled for a job where I would be provided with a decent monthly salary in return for diligently carrying out my allotted tasks, at a company whose small size meant they would value my unremarkable skills. And so it was only natural that I would marry the most run-of-the-mill woman in the world. As for women who were pretty, intelligent, strikingly sensual, the daughters of rich families – they would only ever have served to disrupt my carefully ordered existence.

In keeping with my expectations, she made for a completely ordinary wife who went about things without any distasteful frivolousness. Every morning she got up at six a.m. to prepare rice and soup, and usually a bit of fish. From adolescence she'd contributed to her family's income through the odd bit of part-time work. She ended up with a job as an assistant instructor at the computer graphics college she'd attended for a year, and was subcontracted by a manhwa publisher to work on the words for their speech bubbles, which she could do from home.

She was a woman of few words. It was rare for her to demand anything of me, and however late I was in getting home she never took it upon herself to kick up a fuss. Even when our days off happened to coincide, it wouldn't occur to her to suggest we go out somewhere together. While I idled the afternoon away, TV remote in hand, she would shut herself up in her room. More than likely she would spend the time

reading, which was practically her only hobby. For some unfathomable reason, reading was something she was able to really immerse herself in – reading books that looked so dull I couldn't even bring myself to so much as take a look inside the covers. Only at mealtimes would she open the door and silently emerge to prepare the food. To be sure, that kind of wife, and that kind of lifestyle, did mean that I was unlikely to find my days particularly stimulating. On the other hand, if I'd had one of those wives whose phones ring on and off all day long with calls from friends or co-workers, or whose nagging periodically leads to screaming rows with their husbands, I would have been grateful when she finally wore herself out.

The only respect in which my wife was at all unusual was that she didn't like wearing a bra. When I was a young man barely out of adolescence, and my wife and I were dating, I happened to put my hand on her back only to find that I couldn't feel a bra strap under her sweater, and when I realized what this meant I became quite aroused. In order to judge whether she might possibly have been trying to tell me something, I spent a minute or two looking at her through new eyes, studying her attitude. The outcome of my studies was that she wasn't, in fact, trying to send any kind of signal. So if not, was it laziness, or just a sheer lack of concern? I couldn't get my head round it. It wasn't even as though she had shapely breasts which might suit the 'no-bra look'. I would have preferred her to go around wearing one that was thickly padded, so that I could save face in front of my acquaintances.

Even in the summer, when I managed to persuade her to wear one for a while, she'd have it unhooked barely a minute after leaving the house. The undone hook would be clearly visible under her thin, light-coloured tops, but she wasn't



remotely concerned. I tried reproaching her, lecturing her to layer up with a vest instead of a bra in that sultry heat. She tried to justify herself by saying that she couldn't stand wearing a bra because of the way it squeezed her breasts, and that I'd never worn one myself so I couldn't understand how constricting it felt. Nevertheless, considering I knew for a fact that there were plenty of other women who, unlike her, didn't have anything particularly against bras, I began to have doubts about this hypersensitivity of hers.

In all other respects, the course of our married life ran smoothly. We were approaching the five-year mark, and since we were never madly in love to begin with we were able to avoid falling into that stage of weariness and boredom that can otherwise turn married life into a trial. The only thing was, because we'd decided to put off trying for children until we'd managed to secure a place of our own, which had only happened last autumn, I sometimes wondered whether I would ever get to hear the reassuring sound of a child gurgling 'dada', and meaning me. Until a certain day last February, when I came across my wife standing in the kitchen at day-break in just her nightclothes, I had never considered the possibility that our life together might undergo such an appalling change.

'What are you doing standing there?'

I'd been about to switch on the bathroom light when I was brought up short. It was around four in the morning, and I'd woken up with a raging thirst from the bottle and a half of soju I'd had with dinner, which also meant I was taking longer to come to my senses than usual.

'Hello? I asked what you're doing?'

It was cold enough as it was, but the sight of my wife was even more chilling. Any lingering alcohol-induced drowsiness swiftly passed. She was standing, motionless, in front of the fridge. Her face was submerged in the darkness so I couldn't make out her expression, but the potential options all filled me with fear. Her thick, naturally black hair was fluffed up, dishevelled, and she was wearing her usual white ankle-length nightdress.

On such a night, my wife would ordinarily have hurriedly slipped on a cardigan and searched for her towelling slippers. How long might she have been standing there like that – bare-foot, in thin summer nightwear, ramrod straight as though perfectly oblivious to my repeated interrogation? Her face was turned away from me, and she was standing there so unnaturally still it was almost as if she were some kind of ghost, silently standing its ground.

What was going on? If she couldn't hear me then perhaps that meant she was sleepwalking.

I went towards her, craning my neck to try and get a look at her face.

'Why are you standing there like that? What's going on ...'

When I put my hand on her shoulder I was surprised by her complete lack of reaction. I had no doubt that I was in my right mind and all this was really happening; I had been fully conscious of everything I had done since emerging from the living room, asking her what she was doing, and moving towards her. She was the one standing there completely unresponsive, as though lost in her own world. It was like those rare occasions when, absorbed in a late-night TV drama, she'd

failed to notice me arriving home. But what could there be to absorb her attention in the pale gleam of the fridge's white door, in the pitch-black kitchen at four in the morning?

'Hey!'

Her profile swam towards me out of the darkness. I took in her eyes, bright but not feverish, as her lips slowly parted.

'... I had a dream.'

Her voice was surprisingly clear.

'A dream? What the hell are you talking about? Do you know what time it is?'

She turned so that her body was facing me, then slowly walked off through the open door into the living room. As she entered the room she stretched out her foot and calmly pushed the door to. I was left alone in the dark kitchen, looking helplessly on as her retreating figure was swallowed up through the door.

I turned on the bathroom light and went in. The cold snap had continued for several days now, consistently hovering around  $-10^{\circ}\text{C}$ . I'd showered only a few hours ago, so my plastic shower slippers were still cold and damp. The loneliness of this cruel season began to make itself felt, seeping from the black opening of the ventilation fan above the bath, leaching out of the white tiles covering the floor and walls.

When I went back into the living room my wife was lying down, her legs curled up to her chest, the silence so weighted I might as well have been alone in the room. Of course, this was just my fancy. If I stood perfectly still, held my breath and strained to listen, I was able to hear the faintest sound of breathing coming from where she lay. Yet it didn't sound like the deep, regular breathing of someone who has fallen asleep. I could have reached out to her, and my hand would have

encountered her warm skin. But for some reason I found myself unable to touch her. I didn't even want to reach out to her with words.

For the few moments immediately after I opened my eyes the next morning, when reality had yet to assume its usual concreteness, I lay with the quilt wrapped about me, absent-mindedly assessing the quality of the winter sunshine as it filtered into the room through the white curtain. In the middle of this fit of abstraction I happened to glance at the wall clock and jumped up the instant I saw the time, kicked the door open and hurried out of the room. My wife was in front of the fridge.

'Are you crazy? Why didn't you wake me up? What time is ...'

Something squashed under my foot, stopping me in mid-sentence. I couldn't believe my eyes.

She was crouching, still wearing her nightclothes, her dishevelled, tangled hair a shapeless mass around her face. Around her, the kitchen floor was covered with plastic bags and airtight containers, scattered all over so that there was nowhere I could put my feet without treading on them. Beef for shabu-shabu, belly pork, two sides of black beef shin, some squid in a vacuum-packed bag, sliced eel that my mother-in-law had sent us from the countryside ages ago, dried croaker tied with yellow string, unopened packs of frozen dumplings and endless bundles of unidentified stuff dragged from the depths of the fridge. There was a rustling sound; my wife was busy putting the things around her one by one into black rubbish bags. Eventually I lost control.



'What the hell are you up to now?' I shouted.

She kept on putting the parcels of meat into the rubbish bags, seemingly no more aware of my existence than she had been last night. Beef and pork, pieces of chicken, at least 200,000-won worth of saltwater eel.

'Have you lost your mind? Why on earth are you throwing all this stuff out?'

I hurriedly stumbled my way through the plastic bags and grabbed her wrist, trying to prise the bags from her grip. Stunned to find her fiercely tugging back against me, I almost faltered for a moment, but my outrage soon gave me the strength to overpower her. Massaging her reddened wrist, she spoke in the same ordinary, calm tone of voice she'd used before.

'I had a dream.'

Those words again. Her expression as she looked at me was perfectly composed. Just then my mobile rang.

'Damn it!'

I started to fumble through the pockets of my coat, which I'd tossed onto the living room sofa the previous evening. Finally, in the last inside pocket, my fingers closed around my recalcitrant phone.

'I'm sorry. Something's come up, an urgent family matter, so ... I'm very sorry. I'll be there as quickly as possible. No, I'm going to leave right now. It's just ... no, I couldn't possibly have you do that. Please wait just a little longer. I'm very sorry. Yes, I really can't talk right now ...'

I flipped my phone shut and dashed into the bathroom, where I shaved so hurriedly that I cut myself in two places.

'Haven't you even ironed my white shirt?'

There was no answer. I splashed water on myself and rummaged in the laundry basket, searching for yesterday's shirt. Luckily it wasn't too creased. Not once did my wife bother to peer out from the kitchen in the time it took me to get ready, slinging my tie round my neck like a scarf, pulling on my socks, and getting my notebook and wallet together. In the five years we'd been married this was the first time I'd had to go to work without her handing me my things and seeing me off.

'You're insane! You've completely lost it.'

I crammed my feet into my recently purchased shoes, which were too narrow and pinched uncomfortably, threw open the front door and ran out. I checked whether the lift was going to go all the way up to the top floor, and then dashed down three flights of stairs. Only once I'd managed to jump on the underground train as it was just about to leave did I have time to take in my appearance, reflected in the dark carriage window. I ran my fingers through my hair, did up my tie, and attempted to smooth out the creases in my shirt. My wife's unnaturally serene face, her incongruously firm voice, surfaced in my mind.

*I had a dream* – she'd said that twice now. Beyond the window, in the dark tunnel, her face flitted by – her face, but unfamiliar, as though I was seeing it for the first time. However, as I had thirty minutes in which to concoct an excuse for my client that would justify my lateness, as well as putting together a draft proposal for today's meeting, there was no time for mulling over the strange behaviour of my even-stranger wife. Having said that, I told myself that somehow or other I had to leave the office early today (never mind that in the several months since I'd switched to my new position there hadn't

been a single day where I'd got off before midnight), and steeled myself for a confrontation.

*Dark woods. No people. The sharp-pointed leaves on the trees, my torn feet. This place, almost remembered, but I'm lost now. Frightened. Cold. Across the frozen ravine, a red barn-like building. Straw matting flapping limp across the door. Roll it up and I'm inside, it's inside. A long bamboo stick strung with great blood-red gashes of meat, blood still dripping down. Try to push past but the meat, there's no end to the meat, and no exit. Blood in my mouth, blood-soaked clothes sucked onto my skin.*

*Somehow a way out. Running, running through the valley, then suddenly the woods open out. Trees thick with leaves, spring-time's green light. Families picnicking, little children running about, and that smell, that delicious smell. Almost painfully vivid. The babbling stream, people spreading out rush mats to sit on, snacking on kimbap. Barbecuing meat, the sounds of singing and happy laughter.*

*But the fear. My clothes still wet with blood. Hide, hide behind the trees. Crouch down, don't let anybody see. My bloody hands. My bloody mouth. In that barn, what had I done? Pushed that red raw mass into my mouth, felt it squish against my gums, the roof of my mouth, slick with crimson blood.*

*Chewing on something that felt so real, but couldn't have been, it couldn't. My face, the look in my eyes . . . my face, undoubtedly, but never seen before. Or no, not mine, but so familiar . . . nothing makes sense. Familiar and yet not . . . that vivid, strange, horribly uncanny feeling.*

★

On the dining table my wife had laid out lettuce and soybean paste, plain seaweed soup without the usual beef or clams, and kimchi.

'What the hell? So all because of some ridiculous dream, you've gone and chucked out all the meat? Worth *how* much?'

I got up from my chair and opened the freezer. It was practically empty – nothing but miso powder, chilli powder, frozen fresh chillies, and a pack of minced garlic.

'Just make me some fried eggs. I'm really tired today. I didn't even get to have a proper lunch.'

'I threw the eggs out as well.'

'What?'

'And I've given up milk too.'

'This is unbelievable. You're telling me not to eat meat?'

'I couldn't let those things stay in the fridge. It wouldn't be right.'

How on earth could she be so self-centred? I stared at her lowered eyes, her expression of cool self-possession. The very idea that there should be this other side to her, one where she selfishly did as she pleased, was astonishing. Who would have thought she could be so unreasonable?

'So you're saying that from now on, there'll be no meat in this house?'

'Well, after all, you usually only eat breakfast at home. And I suppose you often have meat with your lunch and dinner, so . . . it's not as if you'll die if you go without meat just for one meal.'

Her reply was so methodical, it was as if she thought that this ridiculous decision of hers was something completely rational and appropriate.

'Oh good, so that's me sorted then. And what about you?'



You're claiming that you're not going to eat meat at all from now on?' She nodded. 'Oh, really? Until when?

'I suppose . . . forever.'

I was lost for words, though at the same time I was aware that choosing a vegetarian diet wasn't quite so rare as it had been in the past. People turn vegetarian for all sorts of reasons: to try and alter their genetic predisposition towards certain allergies, for example, or else because it's seen as more environmentally friendly not to eat meat. Of course, Buddhist priests who have taken certain vows are morally obliged not to participate in the destruction of life, but surely not even impressionable young girls take it quite that far. As far as I was concerned, the only reasonable grounds for altering one's eating habits were the desire to lose weight, an attempt to alleviate certain physical ailments, being possessed by an evil spirit, or having your sleep disturbed by indigestion. In any other case, it was nothing but sheer obstinacy for a wife to go against her husband's wishes as mine had done.

If you'd said that my wife had always been faintly nauseated by meat, then I could have understood it, but in reality it was quite the opposite – ever since we'd got married she had proved herself a more than competent cook, and I'd always been impressed by her way with food. Tongs in one hand and a large pair of scissors in the other, she'd flipped rib meat in a sizzling pan whilst snipping it into bite-sized pieces, her movements deft and practised. Her fragrant, caramelised deep-fried belly pork was achieved by marinating the meat in minced ginger and glutinous starch syrup. Her signature dish had been wafer-thin slices of beef seasoned with black pepper and sesame oil, then coated with sticky rice powder as generously as you would with rice cakes or pancakes, and dipped in

bubbling shabu-shabu broth. She'd made bibimbap with bean-sprouts, minced beef, and pre-soaked rice stir-fried in sesame oil. There had also been a thick chicken and duck soup with large chunks of potato, and a spicy broth packed full of tender clams and mussels, of which I could happily polish off three helpings in a single sitting.

What I was presented with now was a sorry excuse for a meal. Her chair pulled back at an angle, my wife spooned up some seaweed soup, which was quite clearly going to taste of water and nothing else. She balanced rice and soybean paste on a lettuce leaf, then bundled the wrap into her mouth and chewed it slowly.

I just couldn't understand her. Only then did I realize: I really didn't have a clue when it came to this woman.

'Not eating?' she asked absent-mindedly, for all the world like some middle-aged woman addressing her grown-up son. I sat in silence, steadfastly uninterested in this poor excuse for a meal, crunching on kimchi for what felt like an age.

Spring came, and still my wife hadn't backed down. She was as good as her word – I never saw a single piece of meat pass her lips – but I had long since ceased bothering to complain. When a person undergoes such a drastic transformation, there's simply nothing anyone else can do but sit back and let them get on with it.

She grew thinner by the day, so much so that her cheekbones had really become indecently prominent. Without make-up, her complexion resembled that of a hospital patient. If it had all been just another instance of a woman giving up meat in order to lose weight then there would have been no



need to worry, but I was convinced that there was more going on here than a simple case of vegetarianism. No, it had to be that dream she'd mentioned; that was bound to be at the bottom of it all. Although, as a matter of fact, she'd practically stopped sleeping.

No one could describe my wife as especially attentive – often when I returned home late I'd find that she had already fallen asleep. But now I would get in at midnight, and even after I had washed, arranged the bedding, and lain down to sleep, she still wouldn't have come to join me in the living room. She wasn't reading a book, chatting on the internet, or watching late-night cable TV. The only thing I could think of was that she must have been working on the manhwa speech bubbles, but there was no way that would have taken up so much time.

She didn't come to bed until around five in the morning, and even then I couldn't say for sure whether she actually spent the next hour asleep or not. Her face haggard and her hair tangled, she would observe me over the breakfast table through red, narrowed eyes. She wouldn't so much as pick up her spoon, never mind actually eat anything.

But what troubled me more was that she now seemed to be actively avoiding sex. In the past, she'd generally been willing to comply with my physical demands, and there'd even been the occasional time when she'd been the one to make the first move. But now, although she didn't make a fuss about it, if my hand so much as brushed her shoulder she would calmly move away. One day I chose to confront her about it.

'What's the problem, exactly?'

'I'm tired.'

'Well then, that means you need to eat some meat. That's

why you don't have any energy any more, right? You didn't used to be like this, after all.'

'Actually . . .'

'What?'

'... it's the smell.'

'The smell?'

'The meat smell. Your body smells of meat.'

This was just too ridiculous for words.

'Didn't you see me just take a shower? So where's this smell coming from, huh?'

'From the same place your sweat comes from,' she answered, completely in earnest.

Now and then, all of this struck me as being not so much ridiculous as faintly ominous. What if, by chance, these early-stage symptoms didn't pass? If the hints at hysteria, delusion, weak nerves and so on, that I thought I could detect in what she said, ended up leading to something more?

All the same, I found it difficult to believe that she might genuinely be going soft in the head. Ordinarily she was as taciturn as she'd ever been, and continued to keep the home in good order. On weekends she prepared seasoned vegetable side dishes for us to eat during the week, and even made stir-fried glass noodles with mushrooms instead of the usual meat. It wasn't actually all that strange once you took into account that going vegetarian was apparently in vogue. It was only when she hadn't been able to sleep, when the hollows in her face were even more pronounced than usual, as though she'd deflated from within, and in the morning I would ask what the matter was only to hear 'I had a dream'. I never enquired as to the nature of this dream. I'd already had to listen once to that crazy spiel about the barn in the dark woods, the face reflected

in the pool of blood and all the rest of it, and once had been more than enough.

All because of this agonizing dream, from which I was shut out, had no way of knowing and moreover didn't want to know, she continued to waste away. At first she'd slimmed down to the clean, sharp lines of a dancer's physique, and I'd hoped things might stop there, but by now her body resembled nothing so much as the skeletal frame of an invalid. Whenever I found myself troubled by such thoughts, I tried to reassure myself by running through what I knew of her family. Her father worked at a sawmill in a small town, way out in the sticks, where her mother ran a hole-in-the-wall shop, while my sister-in-law and her husband were both regular people, and decent enough – so, at the very least, there didn't seem to be any strain of mental abnormality lurking in my wife's bloodline.

I couldn't think of her family without also recalling the smell of sizzling meat and burning garlic, the sound of shot glasses clinking and the women's noisy conversation emanating from the kitchen. All of them – especially my father-in-law – enjoyed yuk hwe, a kind of beef tartar. I'd seen my mother-in-law gut a live fish, and my wife and her sister were both perfectly competent when it came to hacking a chicken into pieces with a butcher's cleaver. I'd always liked my wife's earthy vitality, the way she would catch cockroaches by smacking them with the palm of her hand. She really had been the most ordinary woman in the world.

Even given the extreme unpredictability of her condition, I wasn't prepared to consider taking her for an urgent medical consultation, much less a course of treatment. There's nothing wrong with her, I told myself, this kind of thing isn't even a

real illness. I resisted the temptation to indulge in introspection. This strange situation had nothing to do with me.

*The morning before I had the dream, I was mincing frozen meat – remember? You got angry.*

*'Damn it, what the hell are you doing squirming like that? You've never been squeamish before.'*

*If you knew how hard I've always worked to keep my nerves in check. Other people just get a bit flustered, but for me everything gets confused, speeds up. Quick, quicker. The hand holding the knife was working so quickly, I felt heat prickle the back of my neck. My hand, the chopping board, the meat, and then the knife, slicing cold into my finger.*

*A drop of red blood already blossoming out of the cut. Rounder than round. Sticking the finger in my mouth calmed me. The scarlet colour, and now the taste, sweetness masking something else, left me strangely pacified.*

*Later that day, when you sat down to a meal of bulgogi, you spat out the second mouthful and picked out something glittering.*

*'What the hell is this?' you yelled. 'A chip off the knife?'*

*I gazed vacantly at your distorted face as you raged.*

*'Just think what would have happened if I'd swallowed it! I was this close to dying!'*

*Why didn't this agitate me like it should have done? Instead, I became even calmer. A cool hand on my forehead. Suddenly, everything around me began to slide away, as though pulled back on an ebbing tide. The dining table, you, all the kitchen furniture. I was alone, the only thing remaining in all of infinite space.*

*Dawn of the next day. The pool of blood in the barn . . . I first saw the face reflected there.*



\*

'What's wrong with your lips? Haven't you done your make-up?'

I took my shoes off again and dragged my flustered wife, who'd already put on her coat, into the front room.

'Were you really going to go out looking like this?' The two of us were reflected in the dressing table mirror. 'Do your make-up again.'

She gently shrugged off my hand, opened her compact and patted the powder puff over her face. The powder made her face somewhat blurry, covering it in motes. The rich coral lipstick she always used to wear, and without which her lips were ashen, went some way to alleviating her sickly pallor. I was reassured.

'We're late. Come on, hurry up.'

I opened the front door and hurried her out, staring impatiently as she fumbled with her dark blue trainers. They didn't go with her black trench coat, but it couldn't be helped. She had no smart shoes left, having thrown out anything made from leather.

As soon as the car engine started I switched on the radio to listen to the traffic bulletin, paying particular attention to any mention of issues near the Korean-Chinese restaurant which the boss had reserved. Once I'd made sure it wouldn't be quicker to go by another route, I fastened my seat belt and released the handbrake. My wife spent a minute fussing with her coat, and finally managed to fasten her seat belt after a couple of failed attempts.

'I need this evening to go well. You know it's the first time the boss has invited me to one of these dinners.'

We only just managed to get to the restaurant in time, and even then only because I'd gone flat out on the main road. The two-storey building, fronted by a spacious car park, was clearly a sophisticated establishment.

The cold of late winter was stubbornly lingering, and my wife looked chilly as she stood in the car park dressed in only a thin spring coat. She hadn't said a single word on the way here, but I convinced myself that this wouldn't be a problem. There's nothing wrong with keeping quiet; after all, hadn't women traditionally been expected to be demure and restrained?

My boss, the managing director and the executive director had already arrived, along with their wives. The section chief and his wife turned up a few minutes after us, completing the party. There were nods and smiles all round as we exchanged greetings, took off our coats and hung them up. My boss's wife, an imposing woman with finely plucked eyebrows and a large jade necklace clacking at her throat, escorted my wife and me over to the dining table, already laid for what promised to be a lavish meal, and sat down at the head of the table. The others all seemed quite at ease, like regulars. I took my seat, careful not to be seen to gawp at the ornate ceiling, which was as elaborately decorated as the eaves of a traditional building. My gaze was arrested by the sight of goldfish swimming lazily in a glass bowl, and I turned to address my wife, but what I saw there brought me up short.

She was wearing a slightly clinging black blouse, and to my utter mortification I saw that the outline of her nipples was clearly visible through the fabric. Without a doubt, she'd come out without a bra. When the other guests surreptitiously craned their necks, no doubt wanting to be sure that they



really were seeing what they thought they were, the eyes of the executive director's wife met mine. Feigning composure, I registered the curiosity, astonishment, and contempt which were revealed in turn in her eyes.

I could feel my cheeks flushing. All too conscious of my wife, sitting there hollow-eyed and making no attempt to join in with the other women's exchange of pleasantries, I controlled myself and decided that the best thing to do, the only thing to do, was to act natural and pretend that there was nothing untoward.

'Did you have any problems finding the place?' my boss's wife asked me.

'No, no, I've been past here once or twice before. In fact, I'd been thinking of coming here myself.'

'Ah, I see . . . yes, the garden has turned out quite well, hasn't it? You ought to try coming in the daytime; you can see the flower beds through that window over there.'

But by the time the food began to be served, the strain of maintaining a casual facade, which I had just about managed so far, was bringing me close to breaking point.

The first thing placed in front of us was an exquisite dish of mung-bean jelly, dressed with thin slivers of green-pea jelly, mushrooms and beef. Up until then my wife had merely sat and observed the scene in silence, but just as the waiter was on the point of ladling some onto her plate, she finally opened her mouth.

'I won't eat it.'

She'd spoken very quietly, but the other guests all instantly stopped what they were doing, directing glances of surprise and wonder at her emaciated body.

'I don't eat meat,' she said, slightly louder this time.

'My word, so you're one of those "vegetarians", are you?' my boss asked. 'Well, I knew that some people in other countries are strict vegetarians, of course. And even here, you know, it does seem that attitudes are beginning to change a little. Now and then there'll be someone claiming that eating meat is bad . . . after all, I suppose giving up meat in order to live a long life isn't all that unreasonable, is it?'

'But surely it isn't possible to live without eating meat?' his wife asked with a smile.

The waiter whisked nine plates away, leaving my wife's still-gleaming plate on the table. The conversation naturally continued on the topic of vegetarianism.

'Do you remember those mummified human remains they discovered recently? Five hundred thousand years old, apparently, and even back then humans were hunting for meat – they could tell that from the skeletons. Meat-eating is a fundamental human instinct, which means vegetarianism goes against human nature, right? It just isn't natural.'

'People mainly used to turn vegetarian because they subscribed to a certain ideology . . . I've been to various doctors myself, to have some tests done and see if there was anything in particular I ought to be avoiding, but everywhere I went I was told something different . . . in any case, the idea of a special diet always made me feel uncomfortable. It seems to me that one shouldn't be too narrow-minded when it comes to food.'

'People who arbitrarily cut out this or that food, even though they're not actually allergic to anything – that's what I would call narrow-minded,' the executive director's wife chimed in; she had been sneaking sideways glances at my wife's breasts for some time now. 'A balanced diet goes hand in hand

with a balanced mind, don't you think?' And now she loosed her arrow directly at my wife. 'Was there some special reason for your becoming a vegetarian? Health reasons, for example ... or religious, perhaps?'

'No.' Her cool reply proved that she was completely oblivious to how delicate the situation had become. All of a sudden, a shiver ran through me – because I had a gut feeling that I knew what she was about to say next.

'I had a dream.'

I hurriedly spoke over her.

'For a long time my wife used to suffer from gastroenteritis, which was so acute that it disturbed her sleep, you see. A dietitian advised her to give up meat, and her symptoms got a lot better after that.'

Only then did the others nod in understanding.

'Well, I must say, I'm glad I've still never sat down with a proper vegetarian. I'd hate to share a meal with someone who considers eating meat repulsive, just because that's how they themselves personally feel ... don't you agree?'

'Imagine you were snatching up a wriggling baby octopus with your chopsticks and chomping it to death – and the woman across from you glared like you were some kind of animal. That must be how it feels to sit down and eat with a vegetarian!'

The group broke out into laughter, and I was conscious of each and every separate laugh. Needless to say, my wife didn't so much as crack a smile. By now, everyone was busy making sure that their mouths were fully occupied with eating, so that it wouldn't be up to them to try and fill the awkward silences that were now peppering the conversation. It was clear that they were all uncomfortable.

The next dish was fried chicken in a chilli and garlic sauce, and after that was raw tuna. My wife sat there immobile while everyone else tucked in, her nipples resembling a pair of acorns as they pushed against the fabric of her blouse. Her gaze roamed intently over the rapidly working mouths of the other guests, delving into every nook and cranny as though intending to soak up every little detail.

By the time the twelve magnificent courses were over, my wife had eaten nothing but salad and kimchi, and a little bit of squash porridge. She hadn't even touched the sticky-rice porridge, as they had used a special recipe involving beef stock to give it a rich, luxurious taste. Gradually, the other guests learned to ignore her presence and the conversation started to flow again. Now and then, perhaps out of pity, they made an effort to include me, but in my heart of hearts I knew that they wanted to keep a certain distance between us.

When fruit was brought out for dessert my wife ate one small slice of apple and a single orange segment.

'You're not hungry? But, my goodness, you've barely eaten anything!' There was something flamboyant about the friendly, sociable tone in which my boss's wife expressed her concern. But the demure, apologetic smile which was the only reasonable response never came, and without even having the grace to look embarrassed, my wife simply stared baldly at my boss's wife. That stare appalled everyone present. Did she not even recognize the situation for what it was? Was it possible that she hadn't grasped the status of the elegant middle-aged woman facing her? What shadowy recesses lurked in her mind, what secrets I'd never suspected? In that moment, she was utterly unknowable.



I didn't know what I could do, exactly, but I knew that I had to do something.

That was the dilemma which tormented me as I drove home. My wife, on the other hand, appeared entirely unperturbed, seemingly unaware of how disgraceful her behaviour had been. She just sat there resting her head against the sloping car window, apparently on the point of dozing off. Naturally, I got angry. Did she want to see her husband get fired? What the hell did she think she was doing?

But I had a feeling that none of it would make the slightest bit of difference. Neither rage nor persuasion would succeed in moving her, and I would be unable to take matters into my own hands.

After washing and putting on her nightclothes she disappeared into her own room rather than getting ready to sleep in the living room as we usually did. I was left pacing up and down when I heard the phone ring: my mother-in-law.

'How is everything with you? I hadn't heard a thing for such a long time ...'

'I'm sorry about that. It's just that I've been so busy lately ... is my father-in-law in good health?'

'Oh, nothing ever changes with us. Are things going well at work?'

I hesitated. 'I'm fine. But as for my wife ...'

'What about Yeong-hye, what's the matter?' Her voice was laced with worry. She had never seemed to show much of an interest in her second daughter, but I suppose one's children are one's children, after all.

'The thing is, she's stopped eating meat.'

'What did you say?'

'She's stopped eating any kind of meat at all, even fish -

all she lives on is vegetables. It's been several months now.'

'What kind of talk is this? Surely you can always just tell her not to follow this diet.'

'Oh, I've told her, all right, but she still goes ahead and defies me. And what's more, she's even imposed this ridiculous diet on me - I can't remember the last time I tasted meat in this house.'

My mother-in-law was lost for words, and I used her speechlessness as an opportunity to turn the screw a little tighter. 'She's become very weak. I'm not sure exactly how serious it is ...'

'I can't have this. Is Yeong-hye there? Pass her the phone.'

'She's gone to bed now. I'll tell her to call tomorrow morning.'

'No, leave it. I'll call. How can that child be so defiant? Oh, you must be ashamed of her!'

After hanging up I riffled through my notebook and dialled my sister-in-law In-hye's number.

My ears were assaulted by the sound of her young son bellowing 'hello?' down the line.

'Please put your mother on.'

In-hye, who quickly took the receiver from her son, resembled my wife quite closely, but her eyes were larger and prettier, and overall she was much more feminine.

'Hello?'

Her voice as it sounded over the phone, always somehow more distinct than in person, never failed to send me into a state of sexual arousal. I informed her of my wife's new-found vegetarianism in the same way as I had just done with her mother, listened to exactly the same sequence of astonishment followed by an apology, and put down the phone after

accepting her assurances. I considered repeating the process by calling my wife's younger brother, Yeong-ho, but decided that that would be overdoing it.

*Dreams of murder.*

*Murderer or murdered . . . hazy distinctions, boundaries wearing thin. Familiarity bleeds into strangeness, certainty becomes impossible. Only the violence is vivid enough to stick. A sound, the elasticity of the instant when the metal struck the victim's head . . . the shadow that crumpled and fell gleams cold in the darkness.*

*They come to me now more times than I can count. Dreams overlaid with dreams, a palimpsest of horror. Violent acts perpetrated by night. A hazy feeling I can't pin down . . . but remembered as blood-chillingly definite.*

*Intolerable loathing, so long suppressed. Loathing I've always tried to mask with affection. But now the mask is coming off.*

*That shuddering, sordid, gruesome, brutal feeling. Nothing else remains. Murderer or murdered, experience too vivid to not be real. Determined, disillusioned. Lukewarm, like slightly cooled blood.*

*Everything starts to feel unfamiliar. Like I've come up to the back of something. Shut up behind a door without a handle. Perhaps I'm only now coming face-to-face with the thing that has always been here. It's dark. Everything is being snuffed out in the pitch-black darkness.*

Contrary to what I'd hoped, my mother- and sister-in-law's efforts at persuasion had not the slightest influence on my wife's eating habits. At the weekend, the phone rang and my wife picked up.

'Yeong-hye,' my father-in-law bellowed, 'are you still not

eating meat?' He'd never used a telephone in his life, and I could hear his excited shouts emerging from the receiver. 'What d'you think you're playing at, hey? Acting like this at your age, what on earth must Mr Cheong think?' My wife stood there in perfect silence, holding the receiver to her ear. 'Why don't you answer? Can you hear me?'

A pan of soup was boiling on the stove, so my wife put the receiver down on the table without a word and disappeared into the kitchen. I stood there for a few moments listening to my father-in-law raging impotently, unaware that there was no one on the other end, then took pity on him and picked up the receiver.

'I'm sorry, Father-in-law.'

'No, I'm the one who's ashamed.'

It shocked me to hear this patriarchal man apologize – in the five years I'd known him, I'd never once heard such words pass his lips. Shame and empathy just didn't suit him. He never tired of boasting about having received the Order of Military Merit for serving in Vietnam, and not only was his voice extremely loud, it was the voice of a man with strongly fixed ideas. *I myself, in Vietnam . . . seven Vietcong . . .* as his son-in-law, I was only too familiar with the beginning of his monologue. According to my wife, he had whipped her over the calves until she was eighteen years old.

'... in any case, you're coming up next month so let's sit her down and have it out then.'

The family get-together scheduled for the second Sunday this coming June was clearly going to be a very big deal. Even if no one said it openly, it was plain to see that they were all getting ready to give my wife a dressing-down.

Whether or not my wife was actually aware of any of this,



she never seemed in the least bit perturbed. Aside from the fact that she deliberately continued to avoid sleeping with me – she'd even taken to sleeping in trousers – on the surface we were still a regular married couple. The only thing that had changed was that in the early hours of the morning, when I groped for my alarm clock, turned it off and sat up, she would be lying there ramrod straight, her eyes gazing upwards in the darkness. After the meal at the restaurant, other people in the company had been noticeably cool towards me, but once the project I'd pushed through began to yield some far-from-negligible profits, all that unpleasantness appeared to have been entirely forgotten.

I sometimes told myself that, even though the woman I was living with was a little odd, nothing particularly bad would come of it. I thought I could get by perfectly well just thinking of her as a stranger, or no, as a sister, or even a maid, someone who puts food on the table and keeps the house in good order. But it was no easy thing for a man in the prime of his life, for whom married life had always gone entirely without a hitch, to have his physical needs go unsatisfied for such a long period of time. So yes, one night when I returned home late and somewhat inebriated after a meal with colleagues, I grabbed hold of my wife and pushed her to the floor. Pinning down her struggling arms and tugging off her trousers, I became unexpectedly aroused. She put up a surprisingly strong resistance and, spitting out vulgar curses all the while, it took me three attempts before I managed to insert myself successfully. Once that had happened, she lay there in the dark staring up at the ceiling, her face blank, as though she were a 'comfort woman' dragged in against her will, and I was the Japanese soldier demanding her services. As soon as I finished she rolled

over and buried her face in the quilt. I went to have a shower, and by the time I returned to bed she was lying there with her eyes closed as if nothing had happened, or as though everything had somehow sorted itself out during the time I'd spent washing myself.

After this first time, it was easier for me to do it again, but each time, I would be seized by strange, ominous premonitions. I was thick-skinned by nature, and certainly wasn't in the habit of entertaining outlandish notions, but the darkness and silence of the living room would strike a chill through me all the same. The following morning, sitting with my wife at the breakfast table – her lips pressed firmly closed as per usual, clearly not paying the slightest bit of attention to anything I might be saying – I would be unable to conceal a feeling of abhorrence when I looked across at her. I couldn't stand the way her expression, which made it seem as though she were a woman of bitter experience, who had suffered many hardships, niggled at my conscience.

It was the evening three days before the family gathering. That day, the humidity in Seoul was the highest on record and the air conditioning was blasting out in all the big shops. After spending all day in the office I was starting to shiver, and so I returned home a little earlier than usual. On opening the front door and catching sight of my wife, I stepped hastily inside and closed the door behind me; it was a corridor apartment, and the last thing I needed was for someone to pass by and peek in. She was sitting leaning against the decorative television cabinet, peeling potatoes, wearing thin white cotton trousers but with her upper body bare to the waist. She had now lost so much weight that her breasts were little more than a pair of small bumps beneath her sharply protruding collarbones.

'Why have you taken your clothes off?' I asked her, trying to force out a laugh.

'Because it's hot,' she answered, neither raising her head nor pausing in what she was doing.

I gritted my teeth. Look at me, I willed her, but without saying the words out loud. Look at me and laugh. Show me that your answer was just a joke. But she didn't laugh. It was eight in the evening and the door to the balcony was open, which meant that the apartment was quite cool, and my wife's shoulders were covered in goose pimples like tiny sesame seeds. The potato peelings were piled up in heaps on sheets of newspaper. Thirty-odd remaining potatoes formed a small mound.

'What are you planning to do with them?' I asked, affecting perfect composure.

'Steam them.'

'All of them?'

'Mm-hm.'

I laughed falteringly and waited for her to laugh in response. But she didn't laugh. She didn't even lift her head.

'I was just, you know . . . hungry.'

*Dreams of my hands around someone's throat, throttling them, grabbing the swinging ends of their long hair and hacking it all off, sticking my finger into their slippery eyeball. Those drawn-out waking hours, a pigeon's dull colours in the street and my resolve falters, my fingers flexing to kill. Next door's cat, its bright tormenting eyes, my fingers that could squeeze that brightness out. My trembling legs, the cold sweat on my brow. I become a different person, a different person rises up inside me, devours me, those hours . . .*

*Saliva pooling in my mouth. The butcher's shop, and I have to clamp my hand over my mouth. Along the length of my tongue to my lips, slick with saliva. Leaking out between my lips, trickling down.*

*If only I could sleep. If I could shrug off consciousness for even just an hour. The house is cold on all these nights, more nights than I can count, when I wake up and pace about in bare feet. Chill like rice or soup that has been left to go cold. Nothing is visible outside the black window. The dark front door rattles now and then, but no one comes to knock on the door or anything like that. By the time I come back to bed and put my hand under the quilt, all the warmth is gone.*

*Sleeping in five-minute snatches. Slipping out of fuzzy consciousness, it's back – the dream. Can't even call it that now. Animal eyes gleaming wild, presence of blood, unearthed skull, again those eyes. Rising up from the pit of my stomach. Shuddering awake, my hands, need to see my hands. Breathe. My fingernails still soft, my teeth still gentle.*

*Can only trust my breasts now. I like my breasts, nothing can be killed by them. Hand, foot, tongue, gaze, all weapons from which nothing is safe. But not my breasts. With my round breasts, I'm okay. Still okay. So why do they keep on shrinking? Not even round any more. Why? Why am I changing like this? Why are my edges all sharpening – what I am going to gouge?*

The sunny south-facing apartment was on the seventeenth floor. True, the view out east was obscured by other buildings, but to the rear the mountains were visible in the distance.



'Now you've forgotten all your worries,' my father-in-law pronounced, taking up his spoon and chopsticks. 'Completely seized the moment!'

Even before she got married, my sister-in-law In-hye had managed to secure an apartment with the income she received from managing a cosmetics store. Leading up to her pregnancy, the store had expanded to three times its original size, and after the birth she insisted on stopping by – only at night, and just for a short while – to make sure that everything was running smoothly in her absence. As soon as my nephew Ji-woo turned three and went to a nursery, she'd apparently started spending all day in the shop again.

I envied her husband. He was an art college graduate who liked to pose as an artist, yet didn't contribute a single penny to their household finances. True, he had some property that he'd inherited, but he didn't bring in a salary – in fact, his activities were limited to sitting around and not doing an awful lot of anything. Now that In-hye had rolled up her sleeves and gone back to work, her husband was free to spend his whole life messing about with 'art', without a single worry to trouble his comfortable existence. Not only that, but In-hye was also a skilled cook, just as my wife used to be. Seeing the lunch table she had swiftly set made me feel a sudden pang of hunger. Taking in her nicely filled-out figure, big, double-lidded eyes, and demure manner of speaking, I sorely regretted the many things it seemed I'd ended up losing somehow or other, to have left me in my current plight.

Neither complimenting the house nor thanking her sister for taking the trouble to prepare the food, my wife sat quietly eating rice and kimchi. Those were the only things she touched. Mayonnaise contained egg, so that was another thing

off the menu for her – she didn't so much as stick her chopsticks into the mouth-watering salad.

Her face was blanched, a result of protracted insomnia. A stranger coming across her in the street would have assumed she was a hospital patient. A little earlier, pretty much as soon as we'd both come in through the front door, she'd been summoned to the master bedroom; after a while, my sister-in-law was the first to emerge, and judging from her baffled expression I guessed that my wife had come out without a bra. Sure enough, when I looked closely I could see her light-brown nipples showing through like smudges on the cotton.

'How much was the deposit here?'

'... Really? We went to look at the real estate site yesterday; this apartment had already gone up to around fifty million won. Because next year they will have completed the underground line extension, you see.'

'My brother-in-law certainly has a good head for this kind of thing.'

'What did I do? It was all down to my wife.'

While our polite, amiable conversation carried on in intermittent bursts, the children seemed unable to sit still, hitting each other and making an almighty racket, pausing only to stuff their mouths with food.

'Sister-in-law,' I asked, 'did you prepare all this food yourself?'

She gave me a half-smile.

'Well, I've been doing it bit by bit since the day before yesterday. And those, the seasoned oysters, I went to the market expressly to get because I know Yeong-hye likes them ... and she hasn't even touched them.'

I held my breath. Here it comes, I thought.

'Enough!' my father-in-law yelled. 'You, Yeong-hye! After all I told you, your own father!'

This outburst was followed by In-hye roundly rebuking my wife. 'Do you truly intend to go on like this? Human beings need certain nutrients . . . if you intend to follow a vegetarian diet you should sit down and draw up a proper, well-balanced meal plan. Just look at your face!'

So far my wife's brother Yeong-ho was keeping his own counsel, so his wife decided to have her say instead. 'When I saw her I thought she was a different person. I'd heard about it from my husband, but I never would have guessed that going vegetarian could damage your body like that.'

My mother-in-law brought in dishes of stir-fried beef, sweet and sour pork, steamed chicken, and octopus noodles, arranging them on the table in front of my wife.

'This whole vegetarian business stops right now,' she said. 'This one, and this, and this – hurry up and eat them. How could you have got into this wretched state when there's not a thing in the world you can't eat?'

'Well, what are you waiting for? Come on, eat up,' my father-in-law boomed.

'You must eat, Yeong-hye,' In-hye admonished. 'You'll have more energy if you do. Everyone needs a certain amount of energy while they're alive. Even priests who enter the temple don't take their austerities too far – they might be celibate, but they're still able to live active lives.'

The children were staring wide-eyed at my wife. She turned her blank gaze on her family, as if she couldn't fathom the reason for all this sudden fuss.

A strained silence ensued. I surveyed in turn my father-in-law's swarthy cheeks; my mother-in-law's face, so full of

wrinkles I couldn't believe it had once been that of a young woman, her eyes filled with worry; In-hye's anxiously raised eyebrows; her husband's affected attitude of being no more than a casual bystander; the passive but seemingly displeased expressions of Yeong-ho and his wife. I expected my wife to say something in her own defence, but the sole, silent answer she made to all those glaring faces was to set the pair of chopsticks she had picked up back down on the table.

A small flurry of unease ran through the assembled family. This time, my mother-in-law picked up some sweet and sour pork with her chopsticks and thrust it right up in front of my wife's mouth, saying, 'Here. Come on, hurry up and eat.' Mouth closed, my wife stared at her mother as though entirely ignorant of the rules of etiquette. 'Open your mouth right now. You don't like it? Well, try this instead then.' She tried the same thing with stir-fried beef, and when my wife kept her mouth shut just as before, set the beef down and picked up some dressed oysters. 'Haven't you liked these since you were little? You used to want to eat them all the time . . .'

'Yes, I remember that too,' In-hye chimed in, backing up her mother by making it seem as though my wife not eating oysters was the ultimate big deal. 'I always think of you when I see oysters, Yeong-hye.'

As the chopsticks holding the dressed oysters gradually neared my wife's averted mouth, she twisted away violently.

'Eat it quickly! My arm hurts . . .'

My mother-in-law's arm was actually trembling. Eventually, my wife stood up.

'I won't eat it.'

For the first time in a long while, her speech was clear and distinct.



'What?' my wife's father and brother, who were both similarly hot-tempered, yelled in concert. Yeong-ho's wife quickly grabbed her husband's arm.

'My heart will pack in if this goes on any longer!' my father-in-law shouted at Yeong-hye. 'Don't you understand what your father's telling you? If he tells you to eat, you eat!'

I expected an answer from my wife along the lines of 'I'm sorry, Father, but I just can't eat it', but all she said was 'I do not eat meat' – clearly enunciated, and seemingly not the least bit apologetic.

My mother-in-law gathered up the chopsticks with an attitude of despair. Her old woman's face seemed on the brink of crumpling into tears, tears that would explode from her eyes and then course down her wrinkled cheeks in silence. My father-in-law took up a pair of chopsticks. He used them to pick up a piece of sweet and sour pork and stood tall in front of my wife, who turned away.

My father-in-law stooped slightly as he thrust the pork at my wife's face, a lifetime's rigid discipline unable to disguise his advanced age.

'Eat it! Listen to what your father's telling you and eat. Everything I say is for your own good. So why act like this if it makes you ill?'

The fatherly affection that was almost choking the old man made a powerful impression on me, and I was moved to tears in spite of myself. Probably everyone gathered there felt the same. With one hand my wife pushed away his chopsticks, which were shaking silently in empty space.

'Father, I don't eat meat.'

In an instant, his flat palm cleaved the empty space. My wife cupped her cheek in her hand.

'Father!' In-hye cried out, grabbing his arm. His lips twitched as though his agitation had not yet passed off. I'd known of his incredibly violent temperament for some time, but it was the first time I'd directly witnessed him striking someone.

'Mr Cheong, Yeong-ho, the two of you come here.'

I approached my wife hesitantly. He'd hit her so hard that the blood showed through the skin of her cheek. Her breathing was ragged, and it seemed that her composure had finally been shattered. 'Take hold of Yeong-hye's arms, both of you.'

'What?'

'If she eats it once, she'll eat it again. It's preposterous, everyone eats meat!'

Yeong-ho stood up, looking as though he was finding this whole episode distasteful.

'Sister, would you please just eat? Or after all, it would be simple enough just to pretend. Do you have to make such a thing about it in front of Father?'

'What kind of talk is that?' my father-in-law yelled. 'Grab her arms, quickly. You too, Mr Cheong.'

'Father, why are you doing this?' In-hye took hold of her father's right arm.

Having thrown down the chopsticks, he now picked up a piece of pork with his fingers and approached my wife. She was hesitantly backing away when her brother seized her and sat her down.

'Sister, just behave, okay? Just eat what he gives you.'

'Father, I beg you, stop this,' In-hye entreated him, but he shook her off and thrust the pork at my wife's lips. A moaning sound came from her tightly closed mouth. She was unable to

say even a single word in case, when she opened her mouth to speak, the meat found its way in.

'Father!' Yeong-ho shouted, apparently wanting to dissuade him, though he himself didn't release his grip on my wife.

'Mm-mm . . . mm!'

My father-in-law mashed the pork to a pulp on my wife's lips as she struggled in agony. Though he parted her lips with his strong fingers, he could do nothing about her clenched teeth.

Eventually he flew into a passion again, and struck her in the face once more.

'Father!'

Though In-hye sprang at him and held him by the waist, in the instant that the force of the slap had knocked my wife's mouth open he'd managed to jam the pork in. As soon as the strength in Yeong-ho's arms was visibly exhausted, my wife growled and spat out the meat. An animal cry of distress burst from her lips.

'... get away!'

At first, she drew up her shoulders and seemed about to flee in the direction of the front door, but then she turned back and picked up the fruit knife that had been lying on the dining table.

'Yeong-hye?' My mother-in-law's voice, which seemed about to break, drew a trembling line through the brutal silence. The children burst into noisy sobbing, unable to suppress it any longer.

Jaw clenched, her intent stare facing each one of us down in turn, my wife brandished the knife.

'Stop her . . .'

'Stay back!'

Blood ribboned out of her wrist. The shock of red splashed over white china. As her knees buckled and she crumpled to the floor, the knife was wrested from her by In-hye's husband, who until then had sat through the whole thing as an idle spectator.

'What are you doing? Somebody fetch a towel, at least!' Every inch the special forces graduate, he stopped the bleeding with practised skill, and picked my wife up in his arms. 'Quickly, go down and start the engine!'

I groped for my shoes. The ones I'd picked up weren't a pair, so I had to swap them before I was able to open the front door and go out.

*... the dog that sank its teeth into my leg is chained up to Father's motorcycle. With its singed tail bandaged to my calf wound, a traditional remedy Mother insisted on, I go out and stand at the main gate. I am nine years old, and the summer heat is stifling. The sun has gone down, and still the sweat is running off me. The dog, too, is panting, its red tongue lolling. A white, handsome-looking dog, bigger even than me. Up until it bit the big man's daughter, everyone in the village always thought it could do no wrong.*

*While Father ties the dog to the tree and scorches it with a lamp, he says it isn't to be flogged. He says he heard somewhere that driving a dog to keep running until the point of death is considered a milder punishment. The motorcycle engine starts, and Father begins to drive in a circle. The dog runs along behind. Two laps, three laps, they circle round. Without moving a muscle I stand just inside the gate watching Whitey, eyes rolling and gasping for breath, gradually exhaust himself. Every time his gleaming eyes meet my own I glare even more fiercely.*

*Bad dog, you'd bite me?*



Once it has gone five laps, the dog is frothing at the mouth. Blood drips from its throat, which is being choked with the rope. Constantly groaning through its damaged throat, the dog is dragged along the ground. At six laps, the dog vomits blackish-red blood, trickling from its mouth and open throat. As blood and froth mix together, I stand stiffly upright and stare at those two glittering eyes. Seven laps, and while waiting for the dog to come into view, Father looks behind and sees that it is in fact dangling limply from the motorcycle. I look at the dog's four juddering legs, its raised eyelids, the blood and water in its dead eyes.

That evening there was a feast at our house. All the middle-aged men from the market alleyways came, everyone my father considered worth knowing. The saying goes that for a wound caused by a dog-bite to heal you have to eat that same dog, and I did scoop up a mouthful for myself. No, in fact I ate an entire bowlful with rice. The smell of burnt flesh, which the perilla seeds couldn't wholly mask, pricked my nose. I remember the two eyes that had watched me, while the dog was made to run on, while he vomited blood mixed with froth, and how later they had seemed to appear, flickering, on the surface of the soup. But I don't care. I really didn't care.

The women stayed behind in the house in order to calm the children down. Yeong-ho saw to my mother-in-law, who had fainted, and my brother-in-law and I took my wife to the casualty department of a nearby hospital. Now no longer in a critical condition, she was transferred to a general two-patient room, and only then did we two men become aware that our clothes were stained with dried blood.

My wife fell asleep with an IV needle inserted into her right arm. The two of us observed her sleeping face in silence.

As though some sort of solution were inscribed there. As though, if I only kept on examining her face, I would be able to figure out the answer.

'Could you step outside for a moment?' I asked my brother-in-law. His expression suggested that he had something he wanted to get off his chest, but he limited himself to a non-committal 'all right'. I pulled out 20,000 won from my pocket, which was all I could find in there, and handed it over.

'Please use this to buy a set of clothes from the store.'

'Me? Ah, my wife will bring me some clean clothes when she comes round later.'

Yeong-ho and his wife showed up that evening, with In-hye. Apparently my father-in-law still hadn't calmed down. Their mother kept on stubbornly insisting on coming to the hospital, but Yeong-ho was adamant that she wasn't to go anywhere near the place.

'What on earth went on back there?' Yeong-ho's wife exclaimed. 'And right in front of the children . . .' She must have been crying, as her make-up had run and her eyes were swollen. 'Your father went too far, you know. How can he hit his daughter in front of her husband? Has he always been like this?'

'Of course, he's always been quick-tempered,' In-hye admitted. 'Haven't you seen how Yeong-ho takes after him? But still, now he's older it's not so bad . . .'

Yeong-ho looked put out. 'Why are you putting the blame on me?'

'Though after all,' In-hye continued, ignoring him, 'Yeong-hye refused to say a single word to him, so he was bound to get upset, you know - I mean, she is his daughter . . .'

'Force-feeding her meat was certainly taking it too far, but what made her decide to stop eating it in the first place? And then why the knife? I've never seen such a thing in all my life. However will she look her husband in the face?' Yeong-ho's wife looked still half in shock.

While In-hye was examining my wife, I changed into her husband's T-shirt and went to the sauna upstairs. I washed off the black congealed blood under the shower's lukewarm stream of water. I looked at myself in the mirror, frowning. The whole affair made my flesh crawl. It just didn't seem real. Right then, thinking about my wife didn't cause me shock or confusion so much as an intense feeling of disgust.

After In-hye had gone home, the only people left in the general ward aside from my wife and me were a schoolgirl who'd been admitted with a ruptured intestine, and her parents. They kept on darting sideways glances at me while I stood watch at my wife's bedside, and I could see perfectly well that they were whispering together. But any minute now this long Sunday would be over and Monday would begin, which meant I would no longer have to look at this woman. I expected that Yeong-ho would take my place, and that the day after tomorrow my wife would be discharged. Discharged – in other words, I would once again have to live with this strange, frightening woman, the two of us in the same house. It was a prospect I found difficult to contemplate.

At nine o'clock the next evening I visited the ward. Yeong-ho greeted me with a smile.

'You must be tired, no?' he said.

'How are the children?'

'Ji-woo's dad's staying with them today.'

If only my colleagues had decided to go for drinks after

work, I would have had the perfect excuse to avoid the ward for another two hours. But it was Monday, so there was no chance of any such reprieve.

'How's my wife been?'

'She's just been sleeping. You can see that without having to ask. She ate what they gave her . . . it seems she's going to be okay.'

Yeong-ho was clearly trying to be considerate, and he did manage to soothe my sharp mood a little. A short while after he left, and just as I was thinking to myself that I ought to loosen my tie and freshen up, someone knocked on the door of the ward.

To my surprise, it was my mother-in-law.

'I'm so ashamed to face you,' she began babbling as soon as she came near me.

'There's no need for that. How are you?'

She took a deep breath.

'Well, you see how it is with old age, the slightest shock . . .' She'd brought a shopping bag with her, which she now thrust at me.

'What's this?'

'Something I prepared before we came up to Seoul. You waste away after months without meat, it seems, so . . . eat this together, the two of you. It's black goat. I was afraid that if In-hye and her husband found out they might try and stop me from coming. Try feeding it to Yeong-hye, just tell her it's herbal medicine. I put a load of medicinal stuff in to mask the smell. She's become such a scrawny thing, just a ghost, and now what with losing all that blood . . .'

I was beginning to get sick and tired of this stubborn 'maternal affection'.



'There's no stovetop here, is there? I'll go and see if they have one in the nurses' room.' She took one of the packets out of her bag and left. Repeatedly winding my tie around my hand and clenching it into a ball, I felt myself get more and more worked up, as the irritation returned which Yeong-ho had briefly appeased. Luckily, a short while later my wife woke up. Only then, when I realised how much better this was than if she'd woken up when I was there alone, did my mother-in-law's arrival come to seem like a good thing.

My mother-in-law came back, and was the first thing my wife's eyes fixed on. The older woman's face was wreathed in smiles from the moment she opened the door, whereas my wife's expression was difficult to decipher. She'd spent all day lying in bed and now, whether because of the drip or simply due to swelling, her face was practically bloodless, almost as white as milk.

Holding a steaming paper cup in one hand, my mother-in-law grasped my wife's hand in the other.

'This ...' Her eyes welled with tears. 'Take this. Ah, look at your face.' My wife obediently took the paper cup. 'It's herbal medicine. They say it strengthens the body. Why, in the old days, back before your marriage, we had the very same medicine made up for you, remember?'

My wife sniffed it and shook her head. 'This isn't herbal medicine.' Her expression cheerless and indifferent, and her eyes filled with something strangely like pity, my wife handed the cup back to her mother.

'It is herbal medicine. Just hold your nose and drink it down quickly.'

'I'm not drinking it.'

'Drink it. This is your mother's wish. Even the dead

get their wishes obeyed, but you'd ignore your own mother's?'

She held the cup to my wife's lips.

'Is it really herbal medicine?'

'Of course, I just said so.'

My wife held her nose and took a sip of the black liquid. My mother-in-law was all smiles, exclaiming, 'More, drink more!' Her eyes flashed below their wrinkled lids.

'I'll keep it here and drink it a little later.'

My wife lay back down again.

'What would you like to eat? Shall I buy something sweet to take away the aftertaste?'

'I'm all right.'

All the same, the old woman kept on pestering me to go and find a shop. I refused to be harried into going, and eventually she left the room to find the shop herself. Then my wife pushed her blanket aside and got up.

'Where are you going?'

'The bathroom.'

I picked up the IV bag and followed after her. She hung the bag up inside the toilet and locked the door. And then, accompanied by several groans, vomited up everything in her stomach.

She staggered out of the toilet, trailing the faint smell of gastric juices and the sour tang of semi-digested food. As I hadn't done it for her she was forced to pick up her IV bag with her bandaged left hand, but she didn't hold it high enough and a small amount of blood began to flow back down the tube. Tottering forward, she picked up the bag of black goat her mother had set down by the bed. Her right hand, which clutched the heavy bag, still had the IV needle

embedded in it, but she didn't pay this the slightest bit of notice. Then she left the ward – and I had absolutely no desire to go and find out what she was up to.

After a little while, the door banged loudly enough to make the schoolgirl and her mother frown in disapproval, and my mother-in-law burst in. She had a packet of biscuits in one hand, and the paper shopping bag in the other – I could see even at a glance that the black liquid had burst out.

'Mr Cheong, what on earth were you thinking of, just sitting there like that? Didn't you guess what that child might have been planning?'

More than anything else, I was strongly tempted just to walk out of the ward and go home.

'You, Yeong-hye, do you know how much this is worth? Would you throw it away? Money scraped together with your own parents' sweat and blood! How can you call yourself my daughter?'

The moment I saw my wife, bent at the waist, I noticed her red blood trickling backwards into the IV bag.

'Look at yourself, now! Stop eating meat, and the world will devour you whole. Take a look in a mirror, go on, tell me what you look like!'

Finally, her high-pitched screeching subsided into low sobs. But my wife merely gazed at the sobbing woman as though she were a complete stranger, and eventually, as if having decided that this performance had gone on quite long enough, got back up onto the bed. She pulled the blanket up to her chest and closed her eyes. Only then did I raise the IV bag, now half full of crimson blood.

★

*I don't know why that woman is crying. I don't know why she keeps staring at my face, either, as though she wants to swallow it. Or why she strokes the bandage on my wrist with her trembling hands.*

*My wrist is okay. It doesn't bother me. The thing that hurts is my chest. Something is stuck in my solar plexus. I don't know what it might be. It's lodged there permanently these days. Even though I've stopped wearing a bra, I can feel this lump all the time. No matter how deeply I inhale, it doesn't go away.*

*Yells and howls, threaded together layer upon layer, are enmeshed to form that lump. Because of meat. I ate too much meat. The lives of the animals I ate have all lodged there. Blood and flesh, all those butchered bodies are scattered in every nook and cranny, and though the physical remnants were excreted, their lives still stick stubbornly to my insides.*

*One time, just one more time, I want to shout. I want to throw myself through the pitch-black window. Maybe that would finally get this lump out of my body. Yes, perhaps that might work.*

*Nobody can help me. Nobody can save me. Nobody can make me breathe.*

I packed my mother-in-law off in a taxi and when I got back the ward was dark. The schoolgirl and her mother, presumably fed up with all the commotion, had turned off the television and lights a little ahead of time, and drawn their curtain. My wife was sleeping. I lay down awkwardly on the cramped side bed and tried to fall asleep. I had absolutely no idea how I was going to sort this mess out. Only one thing was clear, and that was that this whole affair was bound to cause me no end of trouble.

When I eventually succeeded in falling asleep, I had a



dream. In the dream, I was killing someone. I thrust a knife into their stomach with all my strength, then reached into the wound and wrenched out the long, coiled-up intestines. Like eating fish, I peeled off all the squishy flesh and muscle and left only the bones. But in the very instant I woke up, I ceased to remember who it was that I had killed.

It was early in the morning, still dark. Driven by a strange compulsion, I pulled back the blanket covering my wife. I fumbled in the pitch-black darkness, but there was no watery blood, no ripped intestines. I could hear the other patient's sleeping breath coming in little gasps, but my wife was unnaturally silent. I felt an odd trembling inside myself, and reached out with my index finger to touch her philtrum. She was alive.

When I woke up again the ward was already light.

'Goodness, you've been sleeping so deeply,' the young girl's mother said. 'You didn't even wake up when they came and brought the food.' She sounded as though she felt rather sorry for me. I saw the meal tray that had been left on the bed. My wife hadn't even opened the rice bowl, had left the meal tray untouched, and gone . . . where? The IV had been pulled out too, and the bloody needle was dangling from the end of the long plastic tube.

'Where did she go?' I asked, wiping away the traces of drool from around my mouth.

'She was already gone when we woke up.'

'What? In that case, you should have woken me, you know.'

'Even if I'd tried to, you sleep like a log . . . of course, I would have woken you if it had seemed like something

had happened.' Her face reddened, either from anger or simple confusion.

I adjusted my clothes and rushed out, looking around impatiently as I passed down the corridor and came to the lift, but my wife was nowhere to be seen. I didn't have time for this. I'd told them at the office that I'd be two hours later than usual getting in; right now my wife should already have been being discharged. I decided that when I took her home I would tell her, and indeed myself, that we should just think of the whole thing as a bad dream.

I took the lift down to the ground floor. She wasn't in the lobby, so I hurried out into the hospital garden, out of breath but making sure to scan the area thoroughly. The only people in the garden were those patients who had already finished their breakfast. The early-morning chill, which would pass off soon enough, was fairly mild even now. You could tell who was a long-term patient based on how they looked – whether fatigued and gloomy, or peaceful. As I drew near the fountain, which was dry, I noticed that there was some kind of commotion; the people gathered there were all looking at something. I pushed my way through them until I had a clear view.

My wife was sitting on a bench by the fountain. She had removed her hospital gown and placed it on her knees, leaving her gaunt collarbones, emaciated breasts and brown nipples completely exposed. The bandage had been unwound from her left wrist, and the blood that was leaking out seemed to be slowly licking at the sutured area. Sunbeams bathed her face and naked body.

'How long has she been sitting there like that?'

'Good grief . . . she looks like she's come from the psychiatric ward, this young woman.'

'What's that she's holding?'

'It looks like she's gripping something.'

'Ah, look over there. They're coming now.'

When I turned to look over my shoulder, a male nurse and a middle-aged guard could be seen hurrying over, their faces grave. I looked at my wife's exhausted face, her lips stained with blood like clumsily applied lipstick. Her eyes, which had been staring fixedly at the gathered audience, met mine. They glittered, as though filled with water.

I thought to myself: I do not know that woman. And it was true. It was not a lie. Nevertheless, and compelled by responsibilities which refused to be shirked, my legs carried me towards her, a movement which I could not for the life of me control.

'Darling, what are you doing?' I murmured in a low voice, picking up the hospital gown and using it to cover her bare chest.

'It's hot, so . . . ' She smiled faintly – her familiar smile, a smile which could not have been more ordinary, and which I had believed I knew so well. 'It's hot, so I just got undressed.' She raised her left hand to shield her forehead from the streaming sunlight, revealing the cuts on her wrist.

'Have I done something wrong?'

I prised open her clenched right hand. A bird, which had been crushed in her grip, tumbled to the bench. It was a small white-eye bird, with feathers missing here and there. Below tooth-marks which looked to have been caused by a predator's bite, vivid red bloodstains were spreading.



